

John Olmsted

john@olmsted.io | <https://olmsted.io> | <https://github.com/qsymmachus>

Skills

I'm a versatile engineer who specializes in working at the points of leverage that have broad impact across an organization. I proactively take on the right problems, drive them to a reliable finish, and bring other leaders along to multiply my impact.

Technically, I'm a backend specialist with deep experience building reliable, performant systems at scale. I have particular strength with event-driven architectures, authentication & authorization, and performance optimization. I take on ambiguous and impactful projects few other engineers could handle.

Organizationally, I operate at the strategic level. I aim to anticipate risk and opportunity months in advance. I collaborate effectively to achieve results, especially in high-ambiguity, cross-cutting technical work where success depends on alignment across multiple teams and disciplines.

Experience

Principal Software Engineer, Lattice 2025/06 – present

- Lead engineer at Lattice, responsible for guiding company engineering strategy and culture.
- As part of the engineering leadership team, I help ground our decisions in a deep understanding of how our systems work.
- Raised the performance bar for our entire application – I sped up median performance by 2x, p99 performance by 1.4x.
 - Experimented boldly to deliver results; for example, using safe in-memory caching of key data.
 - Introduced new frameworks to enforce performance bars so our gains would be durable.
 - Recruited other engineers to make this a cross-cutting effort that democratized expertise.
- Mentored promising engineering talent by guiding them through complex, high risk projects, and knowing when to step in and when to give them space.

Senior Staff Software Engineer, Lattice 2023/06 – 2025/06

- Lead engineer for the entire platform organization.
- Combined a deep understanding of customer needs, as well as the technical possibilities and limitations of our software and systems, to set strategy and direction for the engineering platform.
- Led key initiatives to address the twin problems of scale and risk.
 - Tuned critical functions to run 2-3x orders of magnitude faster, and built tooling to simplify performance optimization.

- Identified and fixed our most pressing application security risks – authn/authz frameworks, tenant scoping.
- Designed and built the framework used for all event-driven flows, which handles tens of millions of events a day.

Staff Software Engineer, Lattice 2021/05 – 2023/06

- Technical lead on the team responsible for core product APIs.
- Worked at a strategic level to make technical bets that anticipated and enabled our company strategy.
 - Placed a big bet on the effective caching of search data, which increased the performance of search functions by two orders of magnitude.
 - Key product features like dynamic group management and field level permissions would not have been possible without these investments.
- Mentored a growing team of engineers, setting the technical bar for the team and guiding multiple engineers to promotions.

Senior Software Engineer II, Credit Karma 2019/06 – 2021/04

- Lead engineer on a team building tools that accelerate the path to production across the company.
- Helped build, optimize, and deploy a distributed system that manages all our service deployments.
 - The system manages thousands of services across +12 Kubernetes clusters.
 - Fronted with a Web UI and CLI that is easy for engineers to use with key safety guardrails.

Senior Software Engineer, Credit Karma, 2017/03 – 2019/05

- Designed and built a performant system for selecting, rendering, and sending notifications.
- Crafted a successful, multi-quarter rollout strategy to safely replace our legacy notification system.
 - My new design tripled notification throughput and daily volume, at half the cost.
 - The system reliably drives ~\$50k of daily revenue.

Software Engineer, Credit Karma, 2015/04 – 2017/03

- Lead engineer for a key user-facing API that provides financial advice.
- Helped lead a complete re-design of our internal member support tools.
 - Cut the time it takes member support specialists to do their jobs in half.

Education

- M.A. history, UC Berkeley, 2013
- M.A. medieval studies, University of Toronto, 2011
- B.A. history, *summa cum laude*, Carleton College, 2009